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Afra Al Nofeli/Gulf News

■ A woman offers prayers at St Joseph's Cathedral catholic church in Abu Dhabi following the death of Pope Francis on Monday.

Pope Francis' funeral on April 26, world leaders expected to attend

The Argentine pontiff, 88, passed away on Monday from a stroke

VATICAN CITY

Pope Francis' funeral will be held on Saturday, the Vatican announced yesterday, as world leaders from US President Donald Trump, France's Emmanuel Macron to Ukraine's Volodymyr Zelenskyy said they would attend to honour the Catholic leader.

The Argentine pontiff, 88, died on Monday from a stroke, less than a month after returning home from five weeks in hospital battling double pneumonia.

His funeral, which is expected to draw huge crowds, will take place at 10am (0800 GMT) on Saturday in the square in front of St Peter's Basilica at the Vatican.

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Francis' coffin — which he previously ordered should be of wood and zinc — will then be taken inside the church and from there to the Rome basilica of Santa Maria Mag-

giore for burial. The date was set by the first so-called "general congregation" of cardinals yesterday morning, which kicked off a centuries-old process that culminates in the election of a new pontiff within three weeks.

Voting eligibility

Cardinals of all ages are invited to the congregations, although only those under the age of 80 are eligible to vote for a new pope in the conclave. The conclave should begin no less than 15 and no more than 20 days after the death of the pope.

The pope's body was moved into the Santa Marta chapel on Monday evening, and his apartment formally sealed, the Vatican said.

— AFP

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UN: Gaza 'land of desperation' amid blockade

'FAMINE NOT JUST A RISK, BUT RAPIDLY UNFOLDING IN ALMOST ALL PARTS'

GENEVA

The United Nations warned yesterday that Gaza was facing deepening hunger 50 days into a total Israeli blockade on all aid entering the war-ravaged Palestinian territory.

"Gaza has become a land of desperation," Philippe Lazzarini, head of the UN agency for Palestinian refugees UNRWA, said on X. "Hunger is spreading and deepening, deliberate and man-made."

After 18 months of devastating war and an Israeli blockade on aid since March 2, the UN has warned of a dire humanitarian situation for the 2.4 million inhabitants of the Palestinian territory.

Israel has accused the Palestinian militant group of diverting aid, which Hamas denies.

The heads of 12 major aid organisations warned last Thursday that "famine is not just a risk, but likely rapidly unfolding in almost all parts" of the territory.

'Total disaster'

"You can see a clear tendency towards total disaster," Jens Laerke, spokesman for the UN humanitarian agency OCHA told reporters in Geneva Tuesday.

"It is true that right now is probably the worst humanitarian situation we have seen throughout the war in Gaza."

26

Gazans killed in the latest Israeli air strikes yesterday

In his post on X, Lazzarini questioned "how much longer until hollow words of condemnation will translate into action to lift the siege, resume a ceasefire and save whatever is left of humanity?"

The UNRWA chief decried that two million people in Gaza, most of them women and children, "are undergoing collective punishment".

"The wounded, sick and elderly are deprived of medical supplies and care," he said, even as humanitarian organisations like UNRWA have thousands of trucks waiting with supplies that risk expiring.

"Humanitarian aid is being used as a bargaining chip and a weapon of war," he charged.

"The siege must be lifted, supplies must flow in, the hostages must be released, the ceasefire must resume."

Meanwhile, a Hamas delegation departed for Cairo to discuss "new ideas" aimed at securing a ceasefire in Gaza, an official from the group said, as Israeli air strikes killed 26 people across the territory yesterday.

— AFP

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